When my brother and I were growing up, there were still ugly tumors of racial bigotry in much of America, including the corner of Illinois where we lived.

At our one local movie theater, blacks and whites had to sit apart—the blacks in the balcony. My mother and father urged my brother and me to bring home our black playmates, to consider them equals, and to respect the religious views of our friends, whatever they were. My brother's best friend was black, and when they went to the movies, Neil sat with him in the balcony. My mother always taught us: "Treat thy neighbor as you would want your neighbor to treat you," and "Judge everyone by how they act, not what they are."

Once my father checked into a hotel during a shoe-selling trip and a clerk told him: "You'll like it here, Mr. Reagan, we don't permit a Jew in the place."

My father, who told us the story later, said he looked at the clerk angrily and picked up his suitcase and left. "I'm a Catholic," he said. "If it's come to the point where you won't take Jews, then some day you won't take *me* either."

Because it was the only hotel in town, he spent the night in his car during a winter blizzard and I think it may have led to his first heart attack.

I had my share of fistfights, including some that started only because I was from an Irish Catholic family. In reality, we were a religiously divided family, but some of my classmates seized on the fact that Jack was a Catholic, and in Dixon that made him—and me—something of an outcast. The other boys claimed the basement of his church was filled with rifles for the day when the Pope was going to try to take over the country, and when I told them Jack said this story was baloney, they called him a liar and that led me to engage some of them in hand-to-hand combat on the playground.